

Good bishops and bad bishops are relative

Positional Judgment

THE IDEA

A bishop restricted by its own pawns on the same color is often called bad. That bishop can still defend important pawns or become strong after a break. A bishop with open diagonals can be ineffective if no targets lie on its color.

WORKED EXAMPLE

A dark-squared bishop behind dark-square pawns may be passive in the middlegame. If it protects every vulnerable pawn and cannot be exchanged safely, it may be an essential defender rather than a piece to sacrifice casually.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

What can improve a restricted bishop without moving it?

ANSWER AND REASONING

Advance or exchange a blocking pawn, open a diagonal, or create targets on its color. Evaluate the pawn change before assuming the bishop must be traded.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

A bishop's prospects depend on the structure you can create.